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ACADEMIC VAULT

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FAA 101: Foundations of Fine and Applied Arts - Drawing, Colour and Form

The studio habits that carry every later course

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Fine & Applied Arts | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

This pack covers observational drawing, proportion and perspective, value and colour theory, composition, and the material differences between drawing, painting, sculpture and design media. It includes a weekly sketchbook routine that builds skill faster than occasional intense sessions.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Draw from observation with correct proportion and simple perspective.
- Use value to describe form and light.
- Apply colour theory in a composition.
- Keep a sketchbook that documents sustained practice.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Observation before expression

Draw what is there before you draw what you feel.

- Sight and measure: use your pencil to compare angles and proportions.
- Block in the largest shapes before detail.
- Check negative space to correct proportion errors.
- One- and two-point perspective for interiors and streets.
- Draw from life daily; photographs flatten form misleadingly.
- Date every page so progress is visible.

Value, light and colour

Value does most of the work of describing form.

- Build a nine-step value scale and use it to check drawings.
- Identify the light source and keep it consistent.
- Look for core shadow, reflected light and cast shadow.
- Colour theory: hue, value, saturation; complementary and analogous schemes.
- Local colour versus perceived colour under light.
- Test colour relationships rather than trusting memory.

> **Squint at it**
> Squinting collapses detail and reveals whether your values hold together. If the drawing collapses, fix the value structure, not the outline.

Media and studio practice

Materials have different affordances; learn them deliberately.

- Graphite: control, shading and erasure.
- Charcoal and conte: bold mass and expressive mark-making.
- Watercolour: transparency, layering and unforgiving corrections.
- Acrylic and oil: opacity, blending and drying differences.
- Clay and relief: form, armature and structural limits.
- Clean up, store work flat and label materials properly.

What art does, and how to talk about it

Fine art is made to be experienced primarily as form and meaning; applied art is made to be used as well. The distinction is institutional rather than absolute - a woven cloth can be both a functional object and a major work - and it changes with context. A masquerade headdress in a museum is fine art; worn in performance it is applied, ritual and social at once.

Analysis of a work begins with description, not judgement. Describe what is there: medium, support, scale, composition, colour, texture, subject, and the marks of making. Only then interpret. The order matters because interpretation without description invents a work that is not in front of you.

Formal elements - line, shape, form, value, colour, texture, space - and principles - balance, contrast, emphasis, rhythm, proportion, unity - are the vocabulary for description. They are not a checklist to be recited; each term should answer a question about how the work produces its effect.

Materials, process and craft

Every medium has a logic. Charcoal responds to pressure and erases; watercolour rewards transparency and punishes correction; oil allows revision and slow blending; clay records every touch before firing; wood has grain that decides composition; textile has drape, weight and repeat. An artwork that ignores its material's logic usually looks like an idea that has not met its medium.

Process is part of content. Whether a surface is built up in layers, carved away, cast, woven or printed changes what the work can say. Learn the basic processes of at least one medium well enough to explain why a specific effect was achievable and another was not.

Nigerian art history includes major traditions of sculpture (Nok terracotta, Ife brass and terracotta heads, Benin bronzes), textile (aso oke, adire, akwete), pottery, leatherwork and body arts, alongside modern and contemporary practice. These are not "craft" in a diminished sense; they are technically sophisticated traditions with their own aesthetic systems.

> **One work, twenty minutes**
> Sit with a single work and write only description for twenty minutes. Interpretation will be better afterwards, because you will have something to interpret.

Context, function and the studio habit

Art is made in conditions. Patronage, religion, politics, market demand, training systems and available materials determine what is possible. The Benin plaques exist because a court could support specialist guilds; contemporary installation art exists because galleries and biennales do. Asking who paid and who was meant to see it answers more questions than asking whether it is beautiful.

Your own studio practice teaches the same lessons faster. Make something weekly, keep a sketchbook with dated entries, annotate failures, and revisit an idea three times rather than starting ten. A sketchbook with honest notes is the strongest evidence of development in an assessment.

Critique is a skill. Say what you see, what you think it does, and what you would change - and separate those three. Receiving critique means asking a clarifying question before defending.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. A description that earns marks

Write 200 words describing a sculpture without evaluating it.

1. State medium, dimensions and support.
2. Describe the subject and pose in plain language.
3. Describe the treatment of surface: tool marks, polish, patina, texture.
4. Describe composition: mass distribution, negative space, viewpoint.
5. Describe colour and light response.
6. Stop. Do not add "beautiful" or "expressive" - those belong in interpretation.

> **What to carry forward**
> Description is a skill with a stopping point. Stop before judgement.

2. Choosing a medium for an idea

You want to show the fragility of a family memory. Which medium, and why?

1. State the idea precisely: memory that survives only through repeated retelling.
2. List candidate media and what each affords: paper (tears, fades), textile (frays, patches), clay (breaks, cannot be repaired invisibly).
3. Choose one and name the specific property that carries the idea.
4. Test it with a small maquette before committing.
5. Document the test and what it revealed.

> **What to carry forward**
> Medium choice is an argument. Name the property that does the work.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Distinguish fine art from applied art, and explain why the distinction is contested.

15 marks

1. Define both by purpose and context.
2. Show the institutional basis of the distinction.
3. Use a Nigerian example where function and aesthetic value coexist.
4. Explain what the distinction obscures: skill hierarchies, gender and colonial classification.

Q2. Analyse the formal elements of a named work you have studied.

20 marks

1. Identify the work, medium and date.
2. Describe line, shape, value, colour, texture and composition with specifics.
3. Explain how two elements work together to produce an effect.
4. Connect form to context or function.
5. Avoid evaluative adjectives until the final sentence.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Reciting the elements of art without applying them to the specific work.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Formal elements. Line, shape, form, value, colour, texture and space used in description.

Principles of design. Balance, contrast, emphasis, rhythm, proportion and unity.

Medium. The material and process used to make a work.

Support. The surface or structure on which a work is made.

Maquette. A small test model made before the final work.

Patina. Surface change produced by age, handling or chemical action.

Negative space. The empty area around and between forms, itself a compositional element.

Value. The relative lightness or darkness of a tone.

Adire. Yoruba resist-dyed textile tradition using indigo.

Aso oke. Yoruba hand-woven cloth, often worn for ceremonies.

Nok terracotta. Early Nigerian figurative sculpture, among the oldest in sub-Saharan Africa.

Critique. Structured feedback separating observation, interpretation and suggestion.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - See

Description.

- Describe one work in 200 words without judgement.
- Label the formal elements you used.
- Repeat with a different medium.

Week 2 - Make

Material logic.

- Test three media on one idea.
- Record what each affords.
- Choose and justify.

Week 3 - Context

Function and patronage.

- Research one Nigerian tradition.
- Identify who made and who used it.
- Explain the training system.

Week 4 - Critique

Assessment language.

- Critique a peer using the three-part method.
- Annotate your sketchbook.
- Write a 20-mark analysis.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any foundations of visual art text covering formal elements and media.
- A survey of Nigerian art history from Nok to contemporary practice.
- A studio guide to the medium you are working in this semester.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why check negative space when drawing?

Answer: Because judging the shapes around an object exposes proportion errors the eye misses when focused on the object.

2. What are the three properties of colour?

Answer: Hue, value and saturation.

3. Name the parts of a cast shadow.

Answer: Core shadow, reflected light and cast shadow; highlight and midtone complete the light structure.

4. Why is daily sketching more effective than occasional long sessions?

Answer: Skill builds through frequent repetition and immediate correction, which short sessions support.

5. What is the difference between local and perceived colour?

Answer: Local colour is the object's inherent colour; perceived colour is how it appears under specific light and surroundings.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Fill ten sketchbook pages from observation.
- [ ] Build a nine-step value scale.
- [ ] Draw one interior in one-point perspective.
- [ ] Paint a simple colour wheel and two schemes.
- [ ] Make a value study of a still life.
- [ ] Experiment with two unfamiliar media.
- [ ] Review your first and last page side by side.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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